

Hot on clay: On the French Open

The French Open looks truly open in both men's and women's sections

The French Open 2025, which got underway on Sunday, at once seems empty and so full of promise. It is the first edition without the now-retired 14-time champion Rafael Nadal, who had established such a stranglehold in Paris that Roland-Garros, during a soul-stirring ceremony on the opening evening, immortalised his footprint — quite literally — on Court Philippe-Chatrier. But in his absence, the field is now open for a new player to stake claim. Defending champion Carlos Alcaraz is the leading candidate and is closely followed by World No. 1 Jannik Sinner. Spaniard Alcaraz has warmed up well, with Masters titles in Monte Carlo and Rome, and the Italian Open triumph, which came with a straight-sets victory over Sinner in the final, seen as the sounding of the bugle. But Sinner, despite the defeat, will not be disheartened. Rome was his first tournament after serving a three-month doping-related suspension, and a five-match winning run, including a 6-0, 6-1 demolition of two-time French Open finalist and World No. 8 Casper Ruud, proved that elite tennis was still part of his muscle memory. Novak Djokovic, the 24-time Major winner, is without a Slam since US Open 2023, his worst run since 2016-18, but by winning in Geneva last week — his 100th Tour-level title — he is, at least, back in the conversation. Alexander Zverev, a semifinalist or better for four successive years in Paris, will want to shrug off his patchy recent form and show that he belongs among the world's best.

The women's field is airier than the men's, for three-time defending champion Iga Swiatek is far from being in tournament-winning form and a handful of stars are jostling to fill the space. The Polish player, hands down the best clay-court practitioner among women of the present era, has not even reached the final of a tune-up event and has an incredibly difficult draw to grapple with. Her principal rival and World No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka looks primed to take advantage even as those like No. 2 Coco Gauff, No. 4 Jasmine Paolini — finalist in 2024 — and No. 7 Qinwen Zheng are snapping at her heels. Three-time Major winner Sabalenka is playing the best tennis of her career, and made the final in Stuttgart on indoor clay before bagging the Madrid trophy recently. Gauff, despite looking undercooked, reached back-to-back finals in Madrid and Rome while Paolini secured the Italian Open. Though without a title in the lead-up, Zheng will have happy memories of Paris, a place where she won the 2024 Olympic singles gold medal. An outside bet would be the all-action Jelena Ostapenko, the Roland-Garros titlist in 2017 who also triumphed in Stuttgart recently. A victory for her will be in line with the women's Tour's propensity to throw up an eclectic array of champions. [Practice Exer.]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

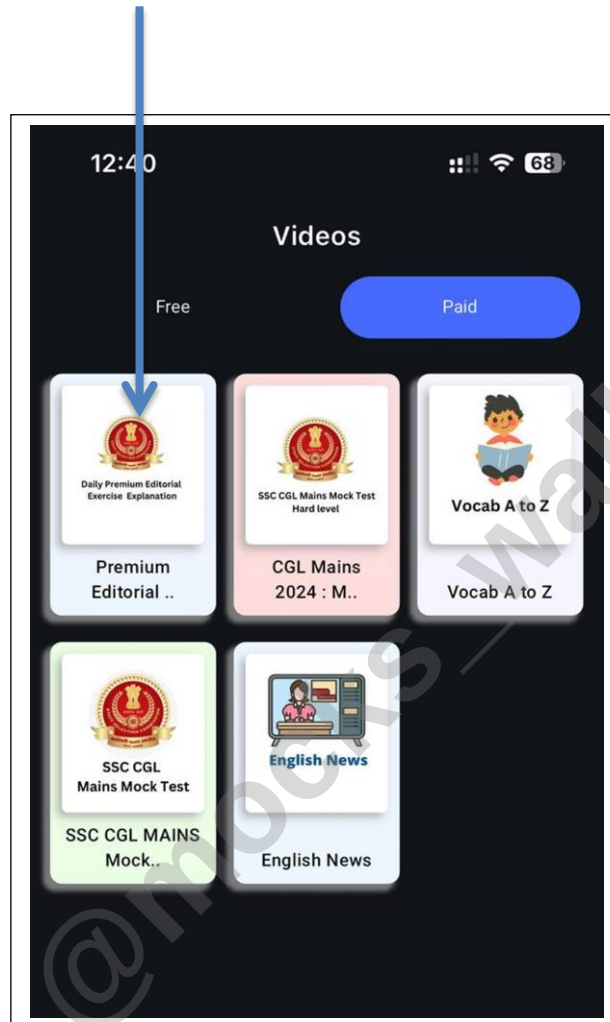
1. **French Open** (noun) – a name for the tennis tournament, officially known as the Internationaux de France de tennis, which is also called Roland Garros
2. **Go underway** (phrase) – commence, begin, start, initiate, kick off शुरू होना
3. **Establish** (verb) – set up, found, build, institute, initiate स्थापित करना
4. **Stranglehold** (noun) – dominance, grip, control, power, hold दबदबा
5. **Roland-Garros** (noun) – the commonly used name for the French Open tennis tournament.
6. **Soul-stirring** (adjective) – emotional, moving, touching, heartfelt, stirring आत्मा को झकझोरने वाला
7. **Immortalise** (verb) – commemorate, enshrine, preserve, honour, celebrate अमर बनाना / स्थायी करना
8. **Footprint** (noun) – impression, trace, mark, legacy, symbol छाप
9. **Literally** (adverb) – actually, truly, factually, plainly, word-for-word वास्तव में
10. **Stake claim** (phrase) – assert, declare, demand, lay claim, announce दावा करना
11. **Defending champion** (noun) – title-holder, reigning champion, current winner, last year's victor, top contender मौजूदा विजेता
12. **Spaniard** (adjective) – Spanish player स्पेन का
13. **Warm up** (phrasal verb) – prepare, practice, get ready, stretch, train अभ्यास करना / तैयार होना
14. **Straight-set** (noun) – a match won without losing a single set बिना सेट गंवाए जीत
15. **The sounding of the bugle** (phrase) – announcement, signal, call to action, declaration, start sign शुरुआत की घोषणा
16. **Disheartened** (adjective) – discouraged, demoralized, disappointed, downcast, upset निराश
17. **Doping** (noun) – drug use, performance-enhancing drugs, banned substances, chemical enhancement, substance abuse नशीले पदार्थों का प्रयोग
18. **Suspension** (noun) – ban, disqualification, removal, exclusion, halt निलंबन
19. **Demolition** (noun) – destruction, dismantling, thrashing, wrecking, crushing जबरदस्त हार / विनाश
20. **Elite** (adjective) – top-level, best, premier, superior, high-ranking उच्च स्तरीय

21. **Muscle memory** (noun) – the ability to reproduce a particular movement without conscious thought, acquired as a result of frequent repetition of that movement.
अभ्यास से प्राप्त शारीरिक स्मृति
22. **Slam** (noun) – refers to a Grand Slam, which means winning all four major tennis championships (Australian Open, French Open, Wimbledon, and US Open) in the same calendar year ग्रैंड स्लैम
23. **Ruin** (noun) – downfall, collapse, failure, decline, destruction पतन / बर्बादी
24. **Successive** (adjective) – consecutive, continuous, following, back-to-back, sequential लगातार
25. **Shrug off** (phrasal verb) – ignore, dismiss, reject, shake off, get over टालना / उपेक्षा करना
26. **Patchy** (adjective) – inconsistent, irregular, uneven, spotty, erratic असंगत / टुकड़ों में
27. **Airier** (adjective) – more open, spacious, less dense, relaxed, breezy खुला / हल्का
28. **A handful of** (phrase) – a few, several, a small number, limited, select कुछ ही
29. **Jostle** (verb) – compete, scramble, push, struggle, vie प्रतिस्पर्धा करना
30. **Hand down** (phrasal verb) – declare, pronounce, give officially, award, deliver देना (निर्णय या विरासत)
31. **Era** (noun) – period, age, epoch, time, generation युग / काल
32. **Tune-up event** (noun) – preparatory match, warm-up game, practice tournament, lead-in event, conditioning round अभ्यास टूर्नामेंट
33. **Grapple with** (phrasal verb) – struggle with, deal with, wrestle with, confront, tackle जूझना
34. **Prime** (verb) – prepare, ready, train, condition, gear up तैयार करना
35. **Snap at one's heels** (phrase) – compete closely, follow closely, pressure, challenge, be right behind कड़ी टक्कर देना
36. **Bag** (verb) – win, capture, grab, clinch, take जीतना / हासिल करना
37. **Undercook** (verb) – be unprepared, be undertrained, lack readiness, be raw, not ready पूरी तरह तैयार न होना
38. **Secure** (verb) – achieve, obtain, gain, grab, win हासिल करना
39. **The lead-up** (noun) – run-up, lead-in, lead time, run-up period, preparation phase – तैयारी का समय
40. **Triumph** (verb) – win, prevail, succeed, conquer, overcome जीतना / विजय पाना
41. **In line with** (phrase) – consistent with, in accordance with, in agreement with, matching, according to के अनुरूप

42. **Propensity** (noun) – tendency, inclination, leaning, predisposition, likelihood प्रवृत्ति
43. **Throw up** (phrasal verb) – produce unexpectedly, generate, give rise to, bring forth, result in उत्पन्न करना / सामने लाना
44. **Eclectic** (adjective) – diverse, varied, wide-ranging, mixed, assorted विविध / बहुविध
45. **Array** (noun) – range, collection, assortment, variety, line-up श्रृंखला / विविधता

@mocks_wallah

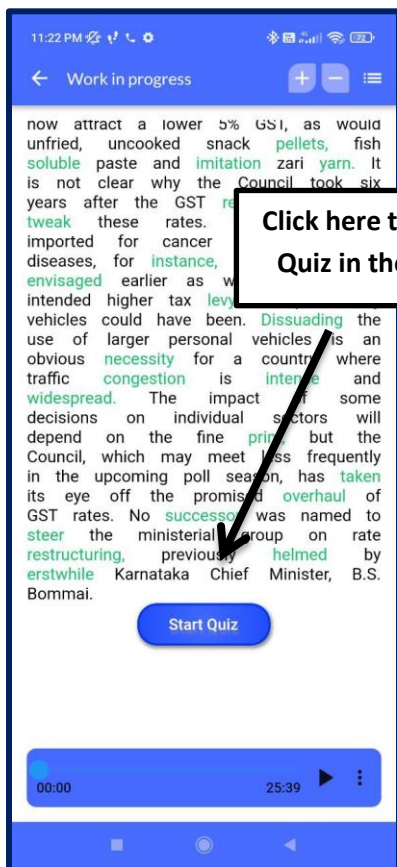
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



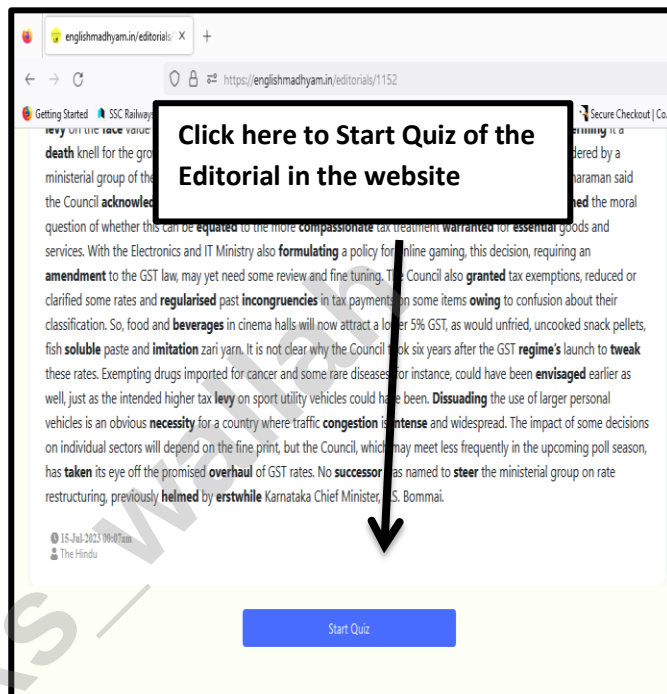
Summary of the Editorial

1. **French Open 2025 Begins:** The tournament started on Sunday, marking a new chapter in tennis history.
2. **Absence of Nadal:** This is the first French Open without Rafael Nadal, the 14-time champion, who was honoured with a ceremony and a literal footprint on Court Philippe-Chatrier.
3. **Open Field in Men's Draw:** With Nadal retired, the men's competition is wide open for a new champion to emerge.
4. **Carlos Alcaraz Favoured:** Defending champion Alcaraz is in top form after recent Masters wins in Monte Carlo and Rome.
5. **Jannik Sinner in Contention:** World No. 1 Sinner is also a strong contender, despite a recent loss to Alcaraz in Rome.
6. **Sinner's Comeback:** Rome marked Sinner's return from a three-month doping suspension; his strong performance signals a promising comeback.
7. **Novak Djokovic's Struggles:** Djokovic hasn't won a Grand Slam since the 2023 US Open, his worst drought since 2016–18.
8. **Djokovic's Revival:** He recently won the Geneva Open, his 100th Tour-level title, keeping him in contention.
9. **Alexander Zverev's Opportunity:** Zverev, a consistent performer in Paris, will aim to break past his recent inconsistent form.
10. **Women's Field Wide Open:** The women's draw is highly competitive and unpredictable this year.
11. **Iga Swiatek's Challenge:** Three-time defending champion Swiatek is struggling, having not reached a final in the clay-court lead-up.
12. **Aryna Sabalenka's Momentum:** World No. 1 Sabalenka is in strong form, winning Madrid after a final appearance in Stuttgart.
13. **Other Women Contenders:** Coco Gauff, Jasmine Paolini, and Qinwen Zheng are key challengers, all showing good recent form.
14. **Jelena Ostapenko as Wildcard:** The 2017 champion and recent Stuttgart winner could surprise with a deep run.
15. **Unpredictable Women's Tour:** The editorial notes the women's tour often produces varied champions, making the French Open particularly intriguing this year.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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